PEW RESEARCH CENTER FOR THE PEOPLE & THE PRESS
AUGUST 2009 OMNIBUS SURVEY
FINAL TOPLINE
August 27-30, 2009
N=1,005

ASK ALL:
Q.1 What do you think is the most important problem facing the country today? **[RECORD VERBATIM RESPONSE. PROBE FOR CLARITY – DO NOT PROBE FOR ADDITIONAL MENTIONS. IF MORE THAN ONE MENTION, RECORD IN ORDER OF MENTION]**

		Early							Mid-			Mid-							
		Feb	Oct	July	Jan	Nov	Sept	Jan	Sept	Jan	May	Jan	July	Jan	Apr	Feb	Mar	May	Feb
		09	08	08	08	07	07	07	06	06	05	05	04	04	03	03	02	01	01[1]
27	Economy (general)	53	55	39	20	14	10	5	9	11	15	12	14	20	28	21	8	7	7
20	Health care/costs	3	4	3	10	7	7	8	4	6	7	5	5	5	3	2	2	6	7
19	Unemployment/Lack of jobs	31	9	5	5	4	3	5	4	7	7	7	8	13	10	6	4	5	6
7	Financial crisis	16	26	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--
6	Deficit/National debt/Balanced budget/Govt spending	4	1	1	2	3	1	1	1	2	2	3	1	2	2	--	1	1	1
5	War/War in Iraq/War in Afghan.	3	11	17	27	32	37	42	25	23	24	32	25	16	14	34	10	--	--
5	Dissatisfaction with govt/politics/ Obama/Gov't control/socialism	5	4	3	6	5	7	8	6	5	6	5	7	5	3	5	4	2	5
3	Morality/Ethics/Family values	1	1	3	2	2	3	3	2	4	3	5	4	3	4	5	8	6	12
2	Recession/Depression/Slowing down of the economy	3	1	1	2	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	1	2
2	Education/schools/affording education	1	--	4	4	2	3	4	4	3	2	3	4	3	4	1	4	8	11
1	Defense issues/Military spending/ National & homeland security	1	1	3	3	2	3	1	4	3	2	3	3	3	2	2	5	1	1
1	Immigration	1	1	2	6	6	6	5	6	3	4	1	1	3	1	--	1	1	2
1	Trade/Jobs moving overseas	1	1	1	1	--	--	--	--	2	1	1	2	1	--	--	--	--	--
1	Terrorism	1	2	3	3	4	6	5	14	6	8	10	8	14	9	16	24	1	--
1	U.S. foreign policy/International affairs	1	1	2	2	3	1	--	2	3	1	1	4	2	--	--	--	2	2
1	Abortion	1	1	--	1	1	--	--	--	--	--	1	1	--	--	--	--	1	1
1	Poverty/Hunger/Starvation	1	1	1	3	2	3	3	3	7	2	3	2	3	3	1	2	3	3
1	Crime/Violence/gangs/ justice system	1	--	1	1	1	2	2	2	2	2	2	1	1	1	1	4	4	8
*	Inflation/Diff. in Wages/Costs	2	5	6	3	2	1	--	2	2	2	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	3
9	Other																		
5	Don't know/No answer	3	4	4	5	6	5	7	7	7	5	5	6	4	9	4	8	8	7
10	**(NET) FOREIGN ISSUES/ INTERNATIONAL**	**7**	**18**	**25**	**36**	**40**	**48**	**50**	**47**	**37**	**36**	**49**	**41**	**37**	**29**	**54**	**39**	**3**	**5**
55	**(NET) ECONOMIC**	**80**	**75**	**61**	**34**	**31**	**20**	**15**	**23**	**26**	**31**	**24**	**26**	**35**	**41**	**29**	**16**	**40**	**26**

[1] Complete trend for Q.1 not shown.

ASK IF ANSWER GIVEN IN Q.1 [N=981]:

Q.2 Which political party do you think can do a better job of handling the problem you just mentioned – the Republican Party or the Democratic Party?

	Republican Party	Democratic Party	**(VOL.)** No difference	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
August 27-30, 2009	23	38	28	11
January, 2007	24	42	21	13
January, 2006	27	41	19	13
January, 2005	36	35	18	11
Mid-January, 2004	35	35	14	16
March, 2002	38	27	21	14
January, 1999[2] *(Gallup)*	33	43	n/a	24
April, 1998 *(Gallup)*	40	42	10	8
July, 1996	36	35	18	11
April, 1995	42	32	17	9
July, 1994	36	33	16	15
June, 1993	28	35	23	14
January, 1992	32	41	12	15
May, 1990 *(RVs)*	29	30	31	10
May, 1988	26	38	22	14
January, 1988	30	35	24	11
May, 1987	28	38	24	10

RANDOMIZE Q.3 AND Q.4

ASK ALL:

Thinking about the political parties for a moment…

Q.3 Please tell me if you think each phrase I read better describes the REPUBLICAN Party and its leaders or the DEMOCRATIC Party and its leaders. (First,) which party do you think is better described by the phrase... **[INSERT ITEM; RANDOMIZE]**?

		Republican Party	Democratic Party	**(VOL.)** Both equally	**(VOL.)** Neither	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
a.	Can better manage the federal government					
	August 27-30, 2009	34	38	4	14	10
	October, 2007	32	44	5	9	10
	March, 2007	31	47	3	8	11
	Early October, 2006	34	44	3	9	10
	April, 2006[3]	35	39	3	15	8
	January, 2006	34	40	4	12	10
	Early October, 2005	35	41	3	13	8
	July, 2004	37	40	4	9	10
	Early September, 1998	37	32	8	12	11
	August, 1997	39	33	4	16	8
	July, 1996	45	32	4	12	7
	April, 1995	49	30	3	13	5
	July, 1994	43	31	4	17	5
	May, 1993	36	32	2	17	13
	July, 1992	30	36	1	23	10
	May, 1990	28	20	12	31	9

[2] In January 1999, the "no difference" and "don't know" categories are combined.

[3] In April 2006 and earlier, the item was worded: "Able to manage the federal government well."

Q.3 CONTINUED …

		Republican Party	Democratic Party	(VOL.) Both equally	(VOL.) Neither	(VOL.) DK/Ref
	May, 1988	33	30	10	17	10
	January, 1988	30	28	12	20	10
	May, 1987	24	25	13	28	10
b.	Governs in a more honest and ethical way					
	August 27-30, 2009	26	42	4	20	9
	October, 2007	26	40	6	19	9
	March, 2007	25	43	4	18	10
	Early October, 2006	27	41	4	18	10
	April, 2006[4]	28	36	4	23	9
	January, 2006	30	37	4	19	10
	Early October, 2005	30	40	6	18	6
	July, 2004	34	37	5	15	9
	Early September, 1998	31	28	6	23	12
	March, 1998	28	32	7	24	9
	August, 1997	28	33	5	26	8
	July, 1996	38	37	2	18	5
	April, 1995	35	36	4	19	6
	July, 1994	32	35	6	21	6
c.	Can bring about the kind of changes the country needs					
	August 27-30, 2009	25	47	5	13	9
	October, 2007	26	48	5	11	10
	March, 2007	26	52	4	9	9
	Early October, 2006	28	48	4	10	10
	April, 2006	32	47	2	12	7
	Early October, 2005	32	48	4	9	7
	July, 2004	35	46	3	7	9
	Early September, 1998	34	40	7	8	11
	March, 1998	32	45	7	8	8
	August, 1997	38	40	4	11	7
	July, 1996	39	46	2	7	6
	April, 1995	51	34	4	7	4
	July, 1994	39	42	4	10	5
	May, 1993	30	49	2	10	9
	July, 1992	24	47	2	16	11
	May, 1990	27	31	13	18	11
	May, 1988	27	43	9	11	10
	January, 1988	28	37	14	11	10
	May, 1987	26	36	14	14	10

[4] In April 2006 and earlier, the item was worded: "Governs in an honest and ethical way."

Q.3 CONTINUED …

		Republican Party	Democratic Party	(VOL.) Both equally	(VOL.) Neither	(VOL.) DK/Ref
d.	Is more concerned with the needs of people like me					
	August 27-30, 2009	27	51	4	10	7
	October, 2007	25	54	4	8	9
	March, 2007	26	55	2	7	10
	Early October, 2006	27	55	3	8	7
	April, 2006[5]	28	52	3	10	7
	Early October, 2005	30	52	5	7	6
	July, 2004	30	50	5	8	7
	Early September, 1998	31	46	5	9	9
	March, 1998	30	51	4	8	7
	August, 1997	31	49	3	10	7
	July, 1996	35	50	2	7	6
	April, 1995	39	49	2	7	3
	July, 1994	35	49	4	8	4
	May, 1990	21	42	12	18	7
	May, 1988	23	51	8	11	7
	January, 1988	22	47	11	13	7
e.	Selects better candidates for office					
	August 27-30, 2009	28	46	3	13	11
	October, 2007	32	41	6	10	11
	July, 1998	34	33	9	12	12
	March, 1998[6]	32	33	12	12	11
	July, 1994	40	36	6	13	5
	May, 1990	32	22	21	17	8
	May, 1988	28	30	13	19	10
	January, 1988	31	24	18	18	9
	May, 1987	27	26	25	13	9
f.	Is more influenced by lobbyists and special interests					
	August 27-30, 2009	37	31	17	3	12
	March, 2007	40	30	15	1	14
	Early October, 2006	41	27	16	2	14
	April, 2006	45	28	14	2	11
g.	Is concerned with the needs and interests of the disadvantaged					
	August 27-30, 2009	20	58	6	7	9
	October, 2005	22	61	5	5	7
	July, 2004	23	57	5	6	9
	Early September, 1998	20	57	5	5	13
	March, 1998	16	64	6	6	8
	July, 1996	23	63	3	5	6
	July, 1994	21	65	4	5	5
	May, 1990	14	56	12	10	8
	May, 1987	11	61	14	7	7

[5] In April 2006 and earlier, the item was worded: "Is concerned with the needs of people like me."

[6] In March 1998 and earlier, the item was worded: "Selects good candidates for office."

Q.3 CONTINUED …

		Republican Party	Democratic Party	(VOL.) Both equally	(VOL.) Neither	(VOL.) DK/Ref
h.	Is concerned with the needs and interests of business					
	August 27-30, 2009	55	26	7	4	8
	October, 2005	61	23	8	2	6
	October, 2005[7]	59	22	6	3	10
	July, 2004	61	22	6	3	8
	Early September, 1998	57	23	8	2	10
	March, 1998	63	20	7	2	8
	July, 1996	65	19	8	2	6
	July, 1994	66	23	5	1	5
	May, 1990	57	15	15	5	8
	May, 1987	58	15	16	3	8

RANDOMIZE Q.3 AND Q.4
ASK ALL:

Q.4 Next, please tell me if you think the REPUBLICAN Party or the DEMOCRATIC Party could do a better job in each of the following areas... (First,) which party could do a better job of... **[INSERT ITEM; RANDOMIZE]** How about **[NEXT ITEM]**?[8]

		Republican Party	Democratic Party	(VOL.) Both Equally	(VOL.) Neither	(VOL.) DK/Ref
a.	Dealing with the economy					
	August 27-30, 2009	32	42	6	12	9
	February, 2008	34	53	2	5	6
	October, 2006	32	45	4	5	14
	September, 2006	32	46	5	5	12
	February, 2006	36	46	5	5	8
	Mid-September, 2005	38	44	5	7	6
	July, 2004	34	46	5	5	10
	Late October, 2002 *(RVs)*	37	40	5	6	12
	Early October, 2002 *(RVs)*	37	41	4	5	13
	Early September, 2002	36	36	9	6	13
	January, 2002	43	34	--	5	18
	May, 2001[9]	33	44	8	5	10
	June, 1999	37	43	8	3	9
	March, 1999	39	44	5	3	9
	Early September, 1998	40	38	8	4	10
	March, 1998	40	40	12	3	5
	October, 1994	45	33	5	7	10
	Gallup: October, 1992 *(RVs)*	36	45	10	--	9
	Gallup: October, 1990	37	35	--	--	28

[7] In July 2004 and earlier, the item was worded: "In concerned with the needs and interests of business and other powerful groups."

[8] In January 1999, January 2001, January 2002, and May 2002, the question was worded: "Please tell me which party you think has the best ideas on... the Republican Party or the Democratic Party?"

[9] In May 2001 and earlier, the item was worded: ".. keeping the country prosperous?"

Q.4 CONTINUED …

		Republican Party	Democratic Party	(VOL.) Both Equally	(VOL.) Neither	(VOL.) DK/Ref
b.	Improving the educational system					
	August 27-30, 2009	22	47	8	12	10
	February, 2008	26	55	6	6	7
	October, 2006	27	45	5	6	17
	September, 2006	28	46	7	6	13
	February, 2006	33	44	8	7	8
	Mid-September, 2005	35	44	6	7	8
	July, 2004	29	45	7	7	12
	January, 2002	37	34	--	6	23
	May, 2001	36	38	11	6	9
	January, 2001	40	41	--	7	12
	June, 1999	29	52	7	5	7
	March, 1999	33	46	6	5	10
	January, 1999	26	46	--	7	21
	Early September, 1998	34	42	10	4	10
	March, 1998	29	49	10	5	7
	July, 1994	37	46	4	5	8
	January, 1992	28	48	--	10	14
	May, 1990	30	42	--	14	14
c.	Dealing with the terrorist threat at home					
	August 27-30, 2009	38	32	10	9	12
	February, 2008	45	38	6	4	7
	October, 2006	39	33	7	6	15
	September, 2006	41	32	7	6	14
	February, 2006	46	30	8	7	9
	Mid-September, 2005	45	34	7	6	8
	July, 2004	45	30	6	6	13
	Late October, 2002 *(RVs)*	44	27	11	6	12
	Early October, 2002 *(RVs)*	44	28	7	5	16
	Early September, 2002	44	22	14	6	14
	January, 2002	48	18	--	6	28
d.	Dealing with taxes					
	August 27-30, 2009	38	37	4	11	11
	February, 2008	37	49	2	5	7
	October, 2006	32	40	5	7	16
	September, 2006	30	45	4	9	12
	February, 2006	35	46	5	6	8
	May, 2001	37	40	8	6	9
	June, 1999	38	38	5	7	12
	September, 1998	41	37	7	5	10
	March, 1998	39	40	6	7	8
	October, 1994	43	34	5	9	9

Q.4 CONTINUED …

		Republican Party	Democratic Party	(VOL.) Both Equally	(VOL.) Neither	(VOL.) DK/Ref
e.	Making wise decisions about what to do in Afghanistan					
	August 27-30, 2009	28	37	7	14	13
	TREND FOR COMPARISON:					
	Making wise decisions about what to do in Iraq					
	February, 2008	37	47	3	5	8
	October, 2006	31	39	5	8	17
	September, 2006	33	40	5	8	14
	February, 2006	38	41	3	8	10
	Mid-September, 2005	38	43	5	6	8
	July, 2004	38	40	4	6	12
	Late October, 2002 *(RVs)*	42	33	6	6	13
	Early October, 2002 *(RVs)*	46	30	7	4	13
f.	Reforming the U.S. health care system					
	August 27-30, 2009	27	46	4	14	9
	February, 2008	26	56	3	8	7
	October, 2006	25	46	4	8	17
	September, 2006	24	48	5	10	13
	February, 2006	27	49	6	9	9
	Mid-September, 2005	28	51	4	10	7
	July, 2004	23	50	4	10	13
	Early July, 2003	31	38	6	10	15
	January, 2002[10]	20	45	--	6	29
	January, 2001	30	47	--	7	16
	January, 1999	25	46	--	7	22
	Early September, 1998	31	43	7	7	12
	March, 1998	25	53	6	8	8
	October, 1994	34	41	5	10	10
	July, 1994	34	48	2	8	8
	December, 1993	25	47	--	10	18
	January, 1992	21	56	--	8	15
	May, 1990	20	50	--	16	14
g.	Dealing with the nation's energy problems					
	August 27-30, 2009	25	47	7	9	12
	February, 2008	23	57	5	5	10
	October, 2006	28	44	5	6	17
	September, 2006	27	47	4	7	15
	February, 2006	32	45	6	7	10
	Mid-September, 2005	31	44	6	8	11
	May, 2001	36	34	10	7	13

[10] From 1999 to 2002, the item was worded: "Regulating health maintenance organizations (HMOs) and managed health care plans." In December 1993, the item was worded: "Reforming health care." In January 1992 and May 1990 the item was worded: "Improving health care in the U.S."

Q.4 CONTINUED …

		Republican Party	Democratic Party	(VOL.) Both Equally	(VOL.) Neither	(VOL.) DK/Ref
h.	Making wise decisions about foreign policy					
	August 27-30, 2009	31	44	7	8	9
	February, 2008	40	45	4	4	7
	July, 2004	38	40	4	4	14
	Early September, 2002	40	30	10	6	14
	May, 2001	39	34	11	3	13
	June, 1999	37	36	7	6	14
	March, 1999	42	37	6	4	11
	Early September, 1998	40	31	11	5	13
	March, 1998	41	33	12	4	10
	October, 1994	47	30	7	5	11
	July, 1994[11]	51	31	4	6	8
	December, 1993	49	23	--	10	18
	May, 1990	39	28	--	17	16
i.	Dealing with immigration					
	August 27-30, 2009	31	36	6	13	13
	February, 2008	38	43	4	6	9
	October, 2006	35	33	6	8	18
	September, 2006	32	37	5	10	16
	April, 2006	27	43	6	11	13
	February, 2006	34	38	8	9	11
j.	Reducing the federal budget deficit					
	August 27-30, 2009	35	36	6	13	10
	September, 2006	27	47	4	8	14
	February, 2006	33	45	6	9	7
	Early October, 2005[12]	29	47	6	10	8
	June, 1999	37	41	5	8	9
	July, 1994	42	36	2	13	7
	December, 1993	31	36	--	18	15
k.	Representing your views on abortion					
	August 27-30, 2009	33	41	3	9	14
	September, 2006	33	44	2	6	15
	January, 1992[13]	29	39	--	11	21
	August, 1990	30	40	--	12	18

[11] In July 1994 and May 1990, the item was worded "Making wise decisions about the country's defense policies."

[12] In Early October 2005, the item was asked as a stand alone question. In June 1999, the item was worded: “Keeping the federal budget balanced.” In December 1993 the item was worded: “Reducing the budget deficit.”

[13] In January 1992 and August 1990, the item was worded, “Which political party - the Republican Party or the Democratic party do you think could do a better job of:”

ASK ALL:

D3 In politics TODAY, do you consider yourself a Republican, Democrat, or Independent?

23	Republican
34	Democrat
37	Independent
4	No preference
1	Other party **(VOL.)**
2	Don't know/Refused **(VOL.)**